

CHRISTMAS PARADOXES

Blue denotes power point
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Brown denotes instructions to
technician

TEXT: Luke 2:1-20 (NKJV)

“And it came to pass in those days that a decree went out from Caesar Augustus that all the world should be registered.² This census first took place while Quirinius was governing Syria. ³So all went to be registered everyone to his own city. ⁴Joseph also went up from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth, into Judea, to the

city of David, which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, ⁵to be registered with Mary, his betrothed wife, who was with child. ⁶So it was, that while they were there, the days were completed for her to be delivered. ⁷And she brought forth her firstborn Son, and wrapped Him in swaddling cloths, and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them in the inn. ⁸Now there were in the same country shepherds living out in the fields, keeping watch over their flock by night. ⁹And behold, an angel of the Lord stood before

them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them, and they were greatly afraid. ¹⁰Then the angel said to them, “Do not be afraid, for behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy which will be to all people. ¹¹“For there is born to you this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord. ¹²“And this will be the sign to you: You will find a Babe wrapped in swaddling cloths, lying in a manger.” ¹³And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God and saying: ¹⁴ “Glory to God in the highest, And on earth peace, goodwill toward

*men!” ¹⁵So it was, when the
angels had gone away from
them into heaven, that the
shepherds said to one another,
“Let us now go to Bethlehem
and see this thing that has
come to pass, which the Lord
has made known to us.” ¹⁶And
they came with haste and
found Mary and Joseph, and
the Babe lying in a manger.
¹⁷Now when they had seen
Him, they made widely known
the saying which was told them
concerning this Child. ¹⁸And
all those who heard it
marveled at those things which
were told them by the
shepherds. ¹⁹But Mary kept all*

these things and pondered them in her heart. ²⁰Then the shepherds returned, glorifying and praising God for all the things that they had heard and seen, as it was told them.”

INTRO: Christians are people of faith. There is much about our belief system that cannot be proven by normal accepted practices of rationality. For instance, **no one can explain:**
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- How God spoke the world into existence...
- How God created man from the dust of the ground...

- How a God, without a body could become a man with a body...
- How a Holy God could tolerate thirty-three and one-half years of rubbing shoulders with a sinful society...
- How an all-powerful God could allow His sinless Son to die for the sins of humankind...
- How a God-man, dead for three days, could rise from the dead...
- How Jesus could defy the laws of nature... To walk through walls and make

appearances to His disciples
out of thin air.

- How Jesus could disregard
the law of gravity at
Bethany's launching pad to
ascend to His father...

Many things about Christianity
must be accepted by faith;
therefore we are people of faith.
The Scripture declares that **faith**
pleases God. (LEAVE ON
SCREEN UNTIL NEXT
SLIDE) Ephesians 2:8-9
(NKJV) “*For by grace you*
have been saved through faith,
and that not of yourselves; it is
the gift of God, 'not of works,
lest anyone should boast.”

Hebrews 11:1-3 (NKJV) “Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen. ²For by it the elders obtained a good testimony. ³By faith we understand that the worlds were framed by the word of God, so that the things which are seen were not made of things which are visible.”

Hebrews 11:6 (NKJV) “But without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is, and that He is a rewarder of those who diligently seek Him.”

Though we are people of faith, we realize and readily accept the fact that there are many things about our system of religion that cannot be explained or accepted through logical thinking. There are many paradoxes that populate the Bible, which is the book we accept as our rule of faith and practice.

I thought a paradox was two Doctor's! As it turns out, **A Paradox** is defined as *“A statement that is seemingly contradictory or opposed to common sense and yet is, perhaps, true.”* (Webster) The

Word of God has many paradoxes, yet nowhere in Scripture is the contrast between heaven and earth more evident than in the Christmas story. Luke takes us from the power and fame of Caesar to the weakness and obscurity of a baby in a stable, and then declares the baby in a manger to be a superior to Caesar.

While one of the greatest events in the history of the planet is occurring, the world was paying no attention to what was going on in the manger. For sure, God was paying attention, and Dr. Luke gives a vivid

snapshot of the events
surrounding this wonderful
story.

Paul speaks of this great
paradox in this way, “*For you
know the grace of our Lord
Jesus Christ, that, though He
was rich, yet for your sakes He
became poor, that you through
His poverty might become
rich.*” Talk about role
reversals. This is costly to God
but beneficial to us!

Look at how many times a
paradox occurs in Dr. Luke’s
rendition of the Christmas
story:

I. JESUS EXPERIENCED A HUMAN BIRTH SO THAT WE COULD EXPERIENCE A SPIRITUAL BIRTH...

Luke 2:4- 7 (NKJV) *“Joseph also went up from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth, into Judea, to the city of David, which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, ⁵to be registered with Mary, his betrothed wife, who was with child. ⁶So it was, that while they were there, the days were completed for her to be delivered. ⁷And she brought forth her firstborn Son, and*

wrapped Him in swaddling cloths, and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them in the inn.”

Think of it, God becoming a human being. This is a plan so complex that it boggles the human mind, yet it is a plan so simple that the person with the lowest IQ can understand it.

The thought of God becoming one of us is absolutely stunning to the human mind. If God becomes a human being He voluntarily accepts all the weaknesses, restrictions, and limitations experienced by mere mortals. How could a God so

powerful that He constructed the world, created human life, and spoke the planets into place, condescend to become one of His own creatures? Yet, Doctor Luke describes such an event with great detail, right down to the: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Date and time... Tax time!
- City... Bethlehem!
- Place... A manger!
- Clothing... Swaddling clothes!

If God were going to do such a thing as to become a human being would He not be born to

a royal family in a palace?

Luke tells us He was born into the family of a carpenter and a peasant woman who would raise Him in the small out-of-the-way place called Nazareth.

This in-and-of-itself is a paradox so astounding that it overwhelms the human imagination. If you were writing a movie script for God to become one of us, never in a million years would you imagine such a thing.

What does it mean for God to experience the birth and life of a human being? Man was created perfect and placed in a

perfect world called the Garden of Eden. As perfect as his world was, mankind found a way to mess up his own world. Adam and Eve sinned, thus offending the holiness of God.

As soon as Adam and Eve sinned, God unveiled a plan of reconciliation for a fallen race.

Genesis 3:15 (NKJV) “*And I will put enmity Between you and the woman, And between your seed and her Seed; He shall bruise your head, And you shall bruise His heel.*”

The only way sin could be atoned for was the sacrifice of a perfect human being. Wait a

minute – a *perfect* human being? How could such a thing ever come to pass? From the time Adam and Eve sinned, decades and centuries came and went, yet not one human being could rise to the point of perfection in order to qualify as the sacrifice for sin. Romans 3:23 (NKJV) “***For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.***”

In the Old Testament, the only way a sacrifice could satisfy a Holy God who had been offended by sin, was for that sacrifice to be spotless, blameless, and perfect.

Leviticus 1:1-3 (NKJV) *“Now the LORD called to Moses, and spoke to him from the tabernacle of meeting, saying,
²“Speak to the children of Israel, and say to them: ‘When any one of you brings an offering to the LORD, you shall bring your offering of the livestock—of the herd and of the flock. ³‘If his offering is a burnt sacrifice of the herd, let him offer a male without blemish; he shall offer it of his own free will at the door of the tabernacle of meeting before the LORD.”*

In order to be the supreme sacrifice, this God-man would need to take upon Himself the form of a human being and the only way to do such a thing was to be born into the world through the strength of human flesh. John 3:1-21 (NKJV)

“There was a man of the Pharisees named Nicodemus, a ruler of the Jews. ²This man came to Jesus by night and said to Him, “Rabbi, we know that You are a teacher come from God; for no one can do these signs that You do unless God is with him.” ³Jesus answered and said to him, “Most assuredly, I say to you,

*unless one is born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.*⁴*Nicodemus said to Him, “How can a man be born when he is old? Can he enter a second time into his mother’s womb and be born?”*⁵*Jesus answered, “Most assuredly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God.*⁶*“That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.”*

Though Mary was a virgin, she brought Jesus into the world just like all other human beings

are born. (Story of little boy's who stole a statue of Mary from the Catholic Church and prayed *"God if you ever want to see your mother again..."*)

Centuries before His birth, Isaiah predicted such a thing would come to pass. Isaiah 7:14 (NKJV) ***"Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a Son, and shall call His name Immanuel."*** While describing the birth of Jesus, Matthew quotes Isaiah.

Matthew 1:23 (NKJV) ***"Behold, the virgin shall be with child, and bear a Son, and they shall call His name***

Immanuel,” which is translated, “God with us.”

The bottom line is this... Jesus experienced a human birth so that we could receive a spiritual birth. Ephesians 2:1-6 (NKJV)

“And you He made alive, who were dead in trespasses and sins, ²in which you once walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, the spirit who now works in the sons of disobedience, ³among whom also we all once conducted ourselves in the lusts of our flesh, fulfilling the desires of the flesh and of the

mind, and were by nature children of wrath, just as the others. ⁴But God, who is rich in mercy, because of His great love with which He loved us, ⁵even when we were dead in trespasses, made us alive together with Christ (by grace you have been saved), ⁶and raised us up together, and made us sit together in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus,”

II. JESUS OCCUPIED A STABLE SO THAT WE COULD OCCUPY A MANSION...

Luke 2:4-7 (NKJV) *“Joseph also went up from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth, into Judea, to the city of David, which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, ⁵to be registered with Mary, his betrothed wife, who was with child. ⁶So it was, that while they were there, the days were completed for her to be delivered. ⁷And she brought forth her firstborn Son, and wrapped Him in swaddling cloths, and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them in the inn.”* If we were to sit down to write a

script for God to become a man we would probably begin with where such a happening should take place. We would probably have Him to be born in the most up-to-date hospital in the world, live in the finest mansion on the earth, be educated in the most excellent schools available, and have the best of everything.

According to Dr. Luke's account of the birth of Jesus, **God does not think on the same wavelength as we do.** Isaiah 55:9 (NKJV)
“For as the heavens are higher than the earth, So

**are My ways higher than
your ways, And My
thoughts than your
thoughts.”**

Look at what St. Matthew has
to say about the birth of Jesus.

Matthew 1:18-24 (NKJV)

***“Now the birth of Jesus Christ
was as follows: After His
mother Mary was betrothed to
Joseph, before they came
together, she was found with
child of the Holy Spirit. ¹⁹Then
Joseph her husband, being a
just man, and not wanting to
make her a public example,
was minded to put her away
secretly. ²⁰But while he thought***

about these things, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, “Joseph, son of David, do not be afraid to take to you Mary your wife, for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit.”²¹ “And she will bring forth a Son, and you shall call His name JESUS, for He will save His people from their sins.”²² So all this was done that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the Lord through the prophet, saying:²³ “Behold, the virgin shall be with child, and bear a Son, and they shall call His name Immanuel,” which is

translated, “God with us.” ²⁴

Then Joseph, being aroused
from sleep, did as the angel of
the Lord commanded him and
took to him his wife, ²⁵and did
not know her till she had
brought forth her firstborn
Son. And he called His name
JESUS.” Can you believe it?

The savior of the world born to
a peasant woman and a

carpenter... and in a stable of
all places! Luke 2:6-7 (NKJV)

“So it was, that while they
were there, the days were
completed for her to be
delivered. ⁷And she brought
forth her firstborn Son, and
wrapped Him in swaddling

cloths, and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them in the inn.”

Jesus. Born in a stable? Are you kidding me? How could it be that the savior of the world would be born in a stable?

Why would Jesus be born in a stable? I believe Jesus was born to peasants in a stable so that He could take the most difficult path to the throne.

Thus, He proves to us that the most disadvantaged person can follow His steps to prominence.

Ephesians 2:1-10 (NKJV) “**And you He made alive, who were dead in trespasses and sins, ²in**

*which you once walked
according to the course of this
world, according to the prince
of the power of the air, the
spirit who now works in the
sons of disobedience, ³among
whom also we all once
conducted ourselves in the
lusts of our flesh, fulfilling the
desires of the flesh and of the
mind, and were by nature
children of wrath, just as the
others. ⁴But God, who is rich
in mercy, because of His great
love with which He loved us,
⁵even when we were dead in
trespasses, made us alive
together with Christ (by grace
you have been saved), ⁶and*

raised us up together, and
made us sit together in the
heavenly places in Christ
Jesus, ⁷*that in the ages to come*
He might show the exceeding
riches of His grace in His
kindness toward us in Christ
Jesus. ⁸*For by grace you have*
been saved through faith, and
that not of yourselves; it is the
gift of God, ⁹*not of works, lest*
anyone should boast. ¹⁰*For we*
are His workmanship, created
in Christ Jesus for good works,
which God prepared
beforehand that we should
walk in them.”

Jesus, who was born in a stable, lived thirty-three and a half sinless years, and ascended to the throne of Heaven, beckons to each of us to follow the path He has provided. John 14:1-6 (NKJV) ***“Let not your heart be troubled; you believe in God, believe also in Me. ²“In My Father’s house are many mansions; if it were not so, I would have told you. I go to prepare a place for you. ³“And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again and receive you to Myself; that where I am, there you may be also. ⁴“And where I go you know, and the way you know.”***

⁵Thomas said to Him, “Lord, we do not know where You are going, and how can we know the way?” ⁶Jesus said to him, “I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through Me.”

Though most of us are rich by this world's overall standards, very few of us live in what could be called by the rich and famous (or infamous, whichever the case may be) a mansion. Look at some of the world's most expensive homes: (Googled at http://www.taralyons.com/most_expensivehomes.php) **(PLACE**

EACH HOME ON THE SCREEN AS I TALK ABOUT THEM)

- Updown Court,
Windlesham, England.
Cost: \$138,000,000.00...
This house is bigger than
Buckingham Palace. It has
103 rooms, five swimming
pools, a squash court,
bowling alley, tennis court,
50-seat movie room and
underground garage. The
White House only has a 48-
seat theatre.
- Hala Ranch, Aspen
Colorado. Cost:
\$135,000,000.00... This
ranch is located on 95 Acres

and is currently the most expensive home in the USA. It features 56,000 square feet and 15 bedrooms.

- [Maison de L'Amitie, Palm Beach, Florida. Cost: \\$125,000,000.00...](#) In 2004 Donald Trump bought this little property at a bankruptcy auction. This property has 475 feet of ocean front, and a 100 foot pool.
- [Tranquility, Lake Tahoe, Nevada. Cost: \\$100,000,000.00...](#) This home features 20,000 square feet, a 19-seat movie

theatre, a 3,500- bottle wine cellar, 9 Bedrooms, and 9 bathrooms.

- Istanbul, Turkey. Cost: \$100,000,000.00... This estate is located on the Bosphorus or also called the Istanbul Straight, and features a cool 64 rooms and 30,000 square feet of living area.

Though a vast majority of the people gathered here today live in very nice homes, none of us live in a mansion! Take a look around the room today. Each person who has decided to follow Christ will one day live

in a mansion that would blow
the minds of the rich and
famous. Revelation 21:10-21
(NKJV) *“And he carried me
away in the Spirit to a great
and high mountain, and
showed me the great city, the
holy Jerusalem, descending
out of heaven from God,
¹¹having the glory of God. Her
light was like a most precious
stone, like a jasper stone, clear
as crystal. ¹²Also she had a
great and high wall with twelve
gates, and twelve angels at the
gates, and names written on
them, which are the names of
the twelve tribes of the
children of Israel: ¹³three gates*

on the east, three gates on the north, three gates on the south, and three gates on the west.

¹⁴Now the wall of the city had twelve foundations, and on them were the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb.

¹⁵And he who talked with me had a gold reed to measure the city, its gates, and its wall.

¹⁶The city is laid out as a square; its length is as great as its breadth. And he measured the city with the reed: twelve thousand furlongs. Its length, breadth, and height are equal.

¹⁷Then he measured its wall: one hundred and forty-four cubits, according to the

measure of a man, that is, of an angel. ¹⁸The construction of its wall was of jasper; and the city was pure gold, like clear glass. ¹⁹The foundations of the wall of the city were adorned with all kinds of precious stones: the first foundation was jasper, the second sapphire, the third chalcedony, the fourth emerald, ²⁰the fifth sardonyx, the sixth sardius, the seventh chrysolite, the eighth beryl, the ninth topaz, the tenth chrysoprase, the eleventh jacinth, and the twelfth amethyst. ²¹The twelve gates were twelve pearls: each individual gate was of one

pearl. And the street of the city was pure gold, like transparent glass.”

How is this possible? Jesus was born in a stable so that we could live in a mansion. The problem with the prosperity preachers of our day is that they are preaching that we should be demanding to live in a mansion here. But for the Christian, the reward is oftentimes deferred. Hebrews 11:8-10 (NKJV) *“By faith Abraham obeyed when he was called to go out to the place which he would receive as an inheritance. And he went out, not knowing where he was*

going. ⁹By faith he dwelt in the land of promise as in a foreign country, dwelling in tents with Isaac and Jacob, the heirs with him of the same promise; ¹⁰for he waited for the city which has foundations, whose builder and maker is God.” Hebrews 11:39-40 (NKJV) “And all these, having obtained a good testimony through faith, did not receive the promise, ⁴⁰God having provided something better for us, that they should not be made perfect apart from us.”

III. JESUS ACCEPTED AN EARTHLY MOTHER SO

THAT WE COULD RECEIVE A HEAVENLY FATHER...

Luke 2:4-7 (NKJV) *“Joseph also went up from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth, into Judea, to the city of David, which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, ⁵to be registered with Mary, his betrothed wife, who was with child. ⁶So it was, that while they were there, the days were completed for her to be delivered. ⁷And she brought forth her firstborn Son, and wrapped Him in swaddling cloths, and laid Him in a*

manger, because there was no room for them in the inn.

The first appearance of Jesus was not in a stable in Bethlehem, He was an equal with God in the beginning.

John 1:1-18 (NKJV) “*In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.*” ² *He was in the beginning with God.* ³ *All things were made through Him, and without Him nothing was made that was made.* ⁴ *In Him was life, and the life was the light of men.* ⁵ *And the light shines in the darkness, and the darkness did not comprehend*

it. ⁶There was a man sent from God, whose name was John.

⁷This man came for a witness, to bear witness of the Light, that all through him might believe. ⁸He was not that Light, but was sent to bear witness of that Light. ⁹That was the true Light which gives light to every man coming into the world. ¹⁰

He was in the world, and the world was made through Him, and the world did not know Him. ¹¹He came to His own, and His own did not receive Him. ¹²But as many as received Him, to them He gave the right to become children of God, to those who believe in His name:

*¹³who were born, not of blood,
nor of the will of the flesh, nor
of the will of man, but of God.*

*¹⁴And the Word became flesh
and dwelt among us, and we
beheld His glory, the glory as
of the only begotten of the
Father, full of grace and truth.*

*¹⁵John bore witness of Him
and cried out, saying, “This
was He of whom I said, ‘He
who comes after me is
preferred before me, for He
was before me.’ ” ¹⁶And of His
fullness we have all received,
and grace for grace. ¹⁷For the
law was given through Moses,
but grace and truth came
through Jesus Christ. ¹⁸No one*

has seen God at any time. The only begotten Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, He has declared Him.”

Mary became the mother of Jesus so that we could have a Heavenly Father. Jesus became an earthly son so that we could be inducted into the family of God, thus being adopted by a Heavenly Father.

One of the most overlooked facts about Adam and Eve’s sin in the Garden of Eden is that the sin they committed broke the relationship between Jehovah God and the human

race. Throughout the Old Testament the relationship between God and man was strained, restricted, and limited at best.

Though God found a way to communicate with man during this period of time, it is obvious that the relationship was filled with failure and misgiving on the part of the people as well as anger and swift judgment on the part of God. I suppose you could say that because of sin, the worst-case scenario is that “man’s daddy” became the devil. While dealing with the Scribes and Pharisees when

they brought the woman caught
in the very act of adultery,
Jesus boldly speaks this truth to
them. John 8:42-45 (NKJV)

*“Jesus said unto them, **If God
were your Father, ye would
love me: for I proceeded forth
and came from God; neither
came I of myself, but he sent
me.** ⁴³ **Why do ye not
understand my speech? even
because ye cannot hear my
word.** ⁴⁴ **Ye are of your father
the devil, and the lusts of your
father ye will do. He was a
murderer from the beginning,
and abode not in the truth,
because there is no truth in
him. When he speaketh a lie,***

he speaketh of his own: for he is a liar, and the father of it.

⁴⁵*And because I tell you the truth, ye believe me not.”*

In the best-case scenario, **man** was orphaned at Eden. John

14:12-18 (NKJV) *“Most assuredly, I say to you, he who believes in Me, the works that I do he will do also; and greater works than these he will do, because I go to My Father.*

¹³*“And whatever you ask in My name, that I will do, that the Father may be glorified in the Son. ¹⁴“If you ask anything in My name, I will do it. ¹⁵“If you love Me, keep My*

commandments. ¹⁶“*And I will pray the Father, and He will give you another Helper, that He may abide with you forever —* ¹⁷“*the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees Him nor knows Him; but you know Him, for He dwells with you and will be in you.* ¹⁸“*I will not leave you orphans; I will come to you.*”

I realize there are many here today who do not, and never have had, a close relationship with their earthly father. This is a human tragedy, not unique to our day. The divine design

of the human family is such that children and their parents share a very close relational bond. If you do not have this kind of relationship with your parents it may be a little difficult to get your hands around the following thoughts. My relationship with my earthly father and mother is and always has been a very close bond. It is rare that a day goes by that I do not talk to my parents. They are the most Godly, authentic, down-to-earth Christians I have ever known! I have never heard my dad say a bad thing about anyone. I have never heard him utter a curse word. I

have never known him to be unkind to anyone. I have never seen him smoke a cigarette; I have never seen him drink a beer; I have never seen him do drugs.

So when I say that Jesus had an earthly mother so that I could have a Heavenly Father, I am fully aware of the benefits of such a thing. Matthew 7:11

(NKJV) ***“If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask Him!”***

The similarities between an earthly father and our Heavenly Father: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Protection...
- Provision...
- Discipline...
- Model of proper behavior...
- Appointing children as beneficiaries...

The benefits of having a Heavenly Father are very similar: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The Heavenly Father protects His earthly children... Deuteronomy 33:27-28 (NKJV) “*The*

*eternal God is your refuge,
And underneath are the
everlasting arms; He will
thrust out the enemy from
before you, And will say,
'Destroy!' ²⁸Then Israel
shall dwell in safety, The
fountain of Jacob alone, In
a land of grain and new
wine; His heavens shall
also drop dew."*

- The Heavenly Father provides for His earthly children... Philippians 4:19 (NKJV) "*My God shall supply all your need according to His riches in glory by Christ Jesus.*"

- The Heavenly Father disciplines His earthly children... Revelation 3:19 (NKJV) ***“As many as I love, I rebuke and chasten. Therefore be zealous and repent.”*** Proverbs 3:11-12 (NKJV) ***“My son, do not despise the chastening of the LORD, Nor detest His correction; ¹²For whom the LORD loves He corrects,***
Just as a father the son in whom he delights.”
- The Heavenly Father models proper behavior before His earthly children... 1 Peter 1:15 (NKJV) ***“But as he which***

*hath called you is holy, so
be ye holy in all manner of
conversation.*”

- The Heavenly Father appoints His earthly children as His beneficiaries... Romans 8:16-17 (NKJV) “*The Spirit Himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, ¹⁷and if children, then heirs —heirs of God and joint heirs with Christ, if indeed we suffer with Him, that we may also be glorified together.*”

One of the major differences between an earthly father and the Heavenly Father is that the earthly father dies and leaves his estate to his children, but the Heavenly Father lives to enjoy watching His children benefit from His treasures.

Jesus took upon himself an earthly mother so that we could have a Heavenly Father.

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- On His mother's side, He was a baby born in a manger. On His Father's side, he was living in a world He created...

- On His mother's side, He was from Nazareth. On His Father's side, He was from the New Jerusalem...
- On His mother's side, he was thirty-three and one-half years old. On His Father's side, he was the Ancient of Days...
- On His mother's side, He was human. On His Father's side, He was divine...
- On His mother's side, He was fleshly. On His Father's side He was Heavenly...
- On His mother's side, he rode a donkey. On His

Father's side, He rode upon
the wings of the wind...

- On His mother's side, he
walked in sandals. On His
Father's side He walked
through walls...
- On His mother's side, He
was God Incarnate. On His
Father's side, He was God
Almighty...
- On His mother's side, He
spoke affectionately to His
parents. On His Father's
side, He spoke the world
into existence...
- On His mother's side, He
endured the pain of
suffering. On His Father's

side, He was triumphant
over pain and suffering...

- On His mother's side, He was subject to His parents. On His Father's side, He was given a name above every name...
- On His mother's side, He needed a lamp or a candle for light. On His Father's side, He will be the light of the New Jerusalem...
- On His mother's side, he became thirsty. On His Father's side, he gave the woman at the well water to drink that would quench her thirst for an eternal day...

- On His mother's side, He wept at the tomb of Lazarus; on His Father's side, He called him back to life again...
- On His mother's side, He could be in only one place at a time; on His Father's side, He is omnipresent...
- On His mother's side, He was as gentle as a lamb led to the slaughter; on His Father's side, He is the Lion of the Tribe of Judah...
- On His mother's side, He was buried in a borrowed tomb; on His Father's side He abolished death...

- On His mother's side, His body succumbed to death. On His Father's side, He rose from the dead...
- On His mother's side, He was born in Bethlehem. On His Father's side, He ascended from Bethany's launching pad...

Mary became Jesus earthly mother so that Jehovah could become our Heavenly Father.

IV. JESUS BECAME SUBJECT TO HUMAN LIMITATIONS SO THAT WE COULD BE SET FREE

FROM SIN'S RESTRICTIONS...

Luke 2:4-7 (NKJV) *“Joseph also went up from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth, into Judea, to the city of David, which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, ⁵to be registered with Mary, his betrothed wife, who was with child. ⁶So it was, that while they were there, the days were completed for her to be delivered. ⁷And she brought forth her firstborn Son, and wrapped Him in swaddling cloths, and laid Him in a manger, because there was no*

room for them in the inn.

When Jesus put on the robe of sinful flesh He willingly accepted the restrictions and limitations that such a thing carried with it.

Jesus was God before coming to this earth and as such He was not limited to time or space. 2

Peter 3:8 (NKJV) ***“Beloved, do not forget this one thing, that with the Lord one day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day.”***

ILLUSTRATION: A man was praying one day and he asked God, *“What is a hundred years to you?”* God responded, *“A minute!”* The man asked,

“What is a million dollars to you?” God responded, *“A penny!”* The man asked, *“Can I have a penny?”* God responded, *“In a minute!”*

Though Jesus was a God-man, the man side of the scenario brought with it some limitations and restrictions. God becoming flesh meant that Jesus was limited by time and space.

Of course, Santa Claus is not limited by time or space: *Santa has 31 hours of Christmas to work with, thanks to the different time zones and the rotation of the earth, assuming*

he travels east to west (which seems logical). This works out to 822.6 visits per second. This is to say that for each Christian household with good children, Santa has 1/1000th of a second to park, hop out of the sleigh, jump down the chimney, fill the stockings, distribute the remaining presents under the tree, eat whatever snacks have been left, get back up the chimney, get back into the sleigh and move on to the next house. This guy moves pretty fast to be so large!

Assuming that each of these 91.8 million stops are evenly

*distributed around the earth
(which, of course, we know to
be false but for the purposes of
our calculations we will
accept), we are now talking
about 0.78 miles per household,
a total trip of 71,604,000 miles,
not counting stops to do what
most of us must do at least once
every 31 hours, plus meals and
feeding the reindeer etc...*

*This means that Santa's sleigh
is moving at 650 miles per
second, which is 3,000 times
the speed of sound. For
purposes of comparison, the
fastest man-made vehicle on
earth, the Ulysses space probe,*

moves at a poky 27.4 miles per second - a conventional reindeer can run, tops, 15 miles per hour.

The payload on the sleigh adds another interesting element. Assuming that each child gets nothing more than a medium-sized Lego set (2 pounds), the sleigh is carrying 321,300 tons or 642,600,000 pounds, not counting Santa, who is invariably described as overweight. On land, conventional reindeer can pull no more than 300 pounds. Even granting that "flying reindeer" (see point #1) could

pull TEN TIMES the normal amount, the job cannot be done with eight, or even nine reindeer, Santa will need 214,200 reindeer. This increases the payload - not even counting the weight of the sleigh - to 706,860,000 pounds. Again, for comparison - this is four times the weight of the Queen Elizabeth.

706,860,000 pounds traveling at 650 miles per second creates enormous air resistance - this will heat the reindeer up in the same fashion as spacecrafts re-entering the [earth's atmosphere](#). The lead pair of reindeer will

absorb 14.3 Quintillion joules of [energy](#) per second each. In short, they will burst into flame almost instantaneously, exposing the reindeer behind them, and create deafening sonic booms in their wake. The entire reindeer team will be vaporized within 4.26 thousandths of a second. Santa, meanwhile, will be subjected to centrifugal forces 17,500.06 times greater than [gravity](#). A 250-pound Santa (which seems ludicrously slim) would be pinned to the back of his sleigh by 4,315,015 pounds of force. As good a man as Santa is, I am afraid he along

with all of us is limited by time and space!

ILLUSTRATION: A preacher preached against Santa at Christmas and someone gave a message in tongues at the end of the sermon and the lady who interpreted it said, *“Give Santa a break, he is a good man.”*

Because Jesus was a human being He was limited by time and space. As such, Jesus was a passionate person who had varied experiences: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He laughed...

- He cried...
- He loved...
- He slept...
- He became fatigued...
- He became disappointed...
- He developed relationships...
- He experienced the pain of rejection...
- He experienced the pain of a human body...
- He experienced the mortality of human flesh...

Why does man suffer all these limitations and restrictions?
Because of the curse of sin! In the Garden of Eden man was

neither limited by time nor space! The entire garden was at their disposal, and when they sinned God drove them out of the Garden to prevent them from eating of the Tree of Life and living forever in their sinful condition. Genesis 2:22-24 (NKJV) *“Then the LORD God said, “Behold, the man has become like one of us, to know good and evil. And now, lest he put out his hand and take also of the tree of life, and eat, and live forever”*²³ *therefore the LORD God sent him out of the garden of Eden to till the ground from which he was taken.*²⁴ *So He drove out the*

man; and He placed cherubim at the east of the garden of Eden, and a flaming sword which turned every way, to guard the way to the tree of life.”

Jesus took upon himself the form of sinful flesh. 2

Corinthians 5:21 (NKJV) “He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.”

What benefit is it for us, that Jesus would come to the earth and do such a thing? **(PLACE**

ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- He became flesh so that we could become eternally saved...
- He suffered so that we could live a rejoicing life...
- He denied the enticement to sin so that we could deny it as well...
- He took stripes on His back so that we could be healed...
- He died on that horrible day so that we could live for an eternal day...
- He rose from the dead so that death would no longer have dominion over us...

- He ascended to OUR Heavenly Father so that He could make intercession for us...

How is all this possible? Jesus became subject to the limitations of the flesh so that we could be free from sin's restrictions!

**V. JESUS WAS RECEIVED
BY LOWLY SHEPHERDS
SO THAT WE COULD BE
WELCOMED BY
HEAVENLY ANGELS...**

Luke 2:8-18 (NKJV) “*Now there were in the same country shepherds living out in the*

fields, keeping watch over their flock by night. ⁹And behold, an angel of the Lord stood before them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them, and they were greatly afraid. ¹⁰Then the angel said to them, “Do not be afraid, for behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy which will be to all people. ¹¹“For there is born to you this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord. ¹²“And this will be the sign to you: You will find a Babe wrapped in swaddling cloths, lying in a manger.” ¹³And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising

God and saying: ¹⁴ “Glory to God in the highest, And on earth peace, goodwill toward men!” ¹⁵ So it was, when the angels had gone away from them into heaven, that the shepherds said to one another, “Let us now go to Bethlehem and see this thing that has come to pass, which the Lord has made known to us.” ¹⁶ And they came with haste and found Mary and Joseph, and the Babe lying in a manger. ¹⁷ Now when they had seen Him, they made widely known the saying which was told them concerning this Child. ¹⁸ And all those who heard it

marveled at those things which were told them by the shepherds.” The Christmas story is replete with meaning but nowhere is the paradox of Christmas more pronounced than when the shepherds came to see the Christ child.

Shepherding was a trade that was interwoven into the culture of Old Testament times, but it was a trade that one performed if he could not find a way to excel in the socio-economic culture of the day. **Shepherds were not the kind of persons one would expect to see at the event that would be the**

fulfillment of the Messianic promise. You would expect to see: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Kings...
- Potentates...
- Influencers...
- Political leaders...
- Religious leaders...
- High-society people...
(The upper crust is some crumbs held together by a little dough!)

Yet, here it is, right here in the Christmas story, shepherds were some of the first people to welcome this Godchild into the world! There are many things

about this story that on the surface do not make a lot of sense; in fact, they are downright surprising! One of the shocking things about this story is who God placed on His invitation list to be in attendance at such an event.

Shepherds! Are you sure, shepherds? Yes shepherds!

Why would God invite such a common group of people to the birth of His Son?

I believe the answer to such questions is multi-faceted;

**(PLACE ON THE SCREEN
ONE AT A TIME)**

- God wanted to demonstrate that He was coming to the earth for everyone... John 3:16 (NKJV) ***“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.”***
- God wanted to begin an object lesson that everyone could grasp... (Talk about the shepherding trade in the Old Testament and how we are compared to sheep.)
- God wanted to change His image in the minds of the people... (Talk about the differences between the

way God dealt with people in the Old Testament and the way he chose to deal with them in the New Testament.)

- God wanted those who would accept Him to know that He would be the provider for and the protector of His people...

Psalm 23:1 (NKJV) “*The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want.*”

- God wanted to bring us to the understanding that, at the end of the day, just as a shepherd would bring his sheep into the safety of the sheep-fold; he will gather us

safely home as well... 1

Thessalonians 4:16-19

(NKJV) *“For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. ¹⁷ Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord. ¹⁸ Therefore comfort one another with these words.”*

Jesus was welcomed by
shepherds so that we might be
welcomed by angels! Luke
15:7 (NKJV) ***“I say to you that
likewise there will be more joy
in heaven over one sinner who
repents than over ninety-nine
just persons who need no
repentance.”*** Revelation 7:9-
12 (NKJV) ***“After this I
beheld, and, lo, a great
multitude, which no man could
number, of all nations, and
kindreds, and people, and
tongues, stood before the
throne, and before the Lamb,
clothed with white robes, and
palms in their hands; ¹⁰And
cried with a loud voice, saying,***

Salvation to our God which sitteth upon the throne, and unto the Lamb. ¹¹And all the angels stood round about the throne, and about the elders and the four beasts, and fell before the throne on their faces, and worshipped God, ¹²Saying, Amen: Blessing, and glory, and wisdom, and thanksgiving, and honour, and power, and might, be unto our God for ever and ever. Amen.”

Revelation 20:1-3 (NKJV)

“Then I saw an angel coming down from heaven, having the key to the bottomless pit and a great chain in his hand. ²He laid hold of the dragon, that

*serpent of old, who is the Devil
and Satan, and bound him for
a thousand years; ³and he cast
him into the bottomless pit,
and shut him up, and set a seal
on him, so that he should
deceive the nations no more till
the thousand years were
finished. But after these things
he must be released for a little
while.”*

It may appear to the innocent
by-stander that the shepherds
are out of place in this passage
but their presence was pre-
planned and well thought out!
Jesus was welcomed by

shepherds so that we might be welcomed by angels!

VI. JESUS VACATED HIS GLORY SO THAT WE COULD SHARE HIS GLORY...

Luke 2:8-18 (NKJV) “*Now there were in the same country shepherds living out in the fields, keeping watch over their flock by night. ⁹And behold, an angel of the Lord stood before them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them, and they were greatly afraid. ¹⁰Then the angel said to them, “Do not be afraid, for behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy which*

*will be to all people. ¹¹“For
there is born to you this day in
the city of David a Savior, who
is Christ the Lord. ¹²“And this
will be the sign to you: You
will find a Babe wrapped in
swaddling cloths, lying in a
manger.” ¹³And suddenly there
was with the angel a multitude
of the heavenly host praising
God and saying: ¹⁴“Glory to
God in the highest, And on
earth peace, goodwill toward
men!” ¹⁵So it was, when the
angels had gone away from
them into heaven, that the
shepherds said to one another,
“Let us now go to Bethlehem
and see this thing that has*

come to pass, which the Lord has made known to us.”¹⁶ And they came with haste and found Mary and Joseph, and the Babe lying in a manger.

¹⁷Now when they had seen Him, they made widely known the saying which was told them concerning this Child.¹⁸ And all those who heard it marveled at those things which were told them by the

shepherds.” The events here in the book of Luke were eventful both in Heaven and earth. For earth, it was the greatest reason for celebration to date; for Heaven, it meant the absence of Heavens most prized

possession as well as its most celebrated personality. Jesus left His Heavenly estate to come to earth.

Think of this: Jesus gave up Heaven to come to earth! Why would He do such a thing?

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- He came to do His Fathers will... Luke 2:43-52
(NKJV) *“And when they had fulfilled the days, as they returned, the child Jesus tarried behind in Jerusalem; and Joseph and his mother knew not of it.
⁴⁴But they, supposing him*

to have been in the company, went a day's journey; and they sought him among their kinsfolk and acquaintance. ⁴⁵ And when they found him not, they turned back again to Jerusalem, seeking him. ⁴⁶ And it came to pass, that after three days they found him in the temple, sitting in the midst of the doctors, both hearing them, and asking them questions. ⁴⁷ And all that heard him were astonished at his understanding and answers. ⁴⁸ And when they saw him, they were

*amazed: and his mother
said unto him, Son, why
hast thou thus dealt with
us? behold, thy father and
I have sought thee
sorrowing. ⁴⁹And he said
unto them, **How is it that ye
sought me? wist ye not that
I must be about my
Father's business? ⁵⁰And
they understood not the
saying which he spake unto
them. ⁵¹And he went down
with them, and came to
Nazareth, and was subject
unto them: but his mother
kept all these sayings in
her heart. ⁵²And Jesus
increased in wisdom and***

*stature, and in favour with
God and man”*

- He came to save the human race... Luke 19:10 (NKJV)
“The Son of Man has come to seek and to save that which was lost.”
- He came to restore man to his rightful place of dominance over the devil...
1 Corinthians 10:13
(NKJV) *“There hath no temptation taken you but such as is common to man: but God is faithful, who will not suffer you to be tempted above that ye are able; but will with the temptation also make a way*

to escape, that ye may be
able to bear it.” 1 John 4:4
(NKJV) “Ye are of God,
little children, and have
overcome them: because
greater is he that is in you,
than he that is in the
world.” Isaiah 59:19
(NKJV) “When the enemy
comes in like a flood, The
Spirit of the LORD will lift
up a standard against
him.” Isaiah 54:17 (NKJV)
“No weapon formed
against you shall prosper,
And every tongue which
rises against you in
judgment You shall
condemn. This is the

*heritage of the servants of
the LORD, And their
righteousness is from Me,”
Says the LORD.”*

- He came to be the supreme sacrifice for sin...

Jesus confirmed this to
Pilate. John 18:37 (NKJV)

*”For this cause I was born,
and for this cause I have
come into the world, that I
should bear witness to the
truth. Everyone who is of
the truth hears My voice.”*

1 Timothy 1:15 (NKJV)

*“This is a faithful saying
and worthy of all
acceptance, that Christ*

*Jesus came into the world
to save sinners.”*

In man's fallen state, he has nothing but trouble and heartache to look forward to. Because Jesus left His glory, we have the opportunity to live productive, happy, healthy, fulfilling lives! John 10:10 (NKJV) ***“The thief does not come except to steal, and to kill, and to destroy. I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly.”*** The word ***“Abundantly”*** here means superior! What area of our life

does God intend to make superior for us?

- Our home...
- Our family...
- All human relationships...
- Our physical wellbeing...
- Our financial wellbeing...

He left His glory to make every part of our lives better! Why would we ever think that He would leave such a place for anything less? Matthew 6:33 (NKJV) ***“Seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you.”***

He left His glory not only to deal with the here-and-now, but to make our eternity better in the by-and-by! Matthew 19:29 (NKJV) ***“And everyone who has left houses or brothers or sisters or father or mother or wife or children or lands, for My name’s sake, shall receive a hundredfold, and inherit eternal life.”***

SONG:

Chorus:

*O yes, I’ll live in glory, by and by
I’ll tell and sing love’s story
there on high*

*And with my dear redeemer no
more to die
O yes, I'll live in glory, by and
by*

Jesus left His glory so that He
could populate Heaven with
saints like us!

CONCLUSION:

The end of the story is not
recorded in the Gospel of Luke,
it is found in the book of
Revelation. In Revelation He
who disrobed His Heavenly
garment picks it back up again,
when the greatest paradox in
the history of the world occurs.
Revelation 5:11-13 (NKJV)

*“Then I looked, and I heard
the voice of many angels
around the throne, the living
creatures, and the elders; and
the number of them was ten
thousand times ten thousand,
and thousands of thousands,
¹²saying with a loud voice:*

*“Worthy is the Lamb who was
slain To receive power and
riches and wisdom, And
strength and honor and glory
and blessing!” ¹³And every
creature which is in heaven
and on the earth and under the
earth and such as are in the
sea, and all that are in them, I
heard saying: “Blessing and
honor and glory and power Be*

to Him who sits on the throne,
And to the Lamb, forever and
ever!” Jesus, who was born in

a manger, is honored with:

**(PLACE ON THE SCREEN
ONE AT A TIME)**

- Worship from heaven’s creatures... In the book of Revelation the angels, elders, and saints worship Him who sits on the throne.
- All the power of Heaven and earth... Matthew 28:18 (KJV) “*All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.*”
- All of Heaven’s riches... Heaven is a city that is adorned with streets of

gold, walls of jasper, and gates of pearl.

- All the wisdom of the Godhead.... Colossians 2:9-10 (KJV) ***“In him dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily. ¹⁰ And ye are complete in him, which is the head of all principality and power.”***
- All the strength of Heaven and earth...
- All the honor of the Heavenly beings and the inhabitants of earth...
Philippians 2:8-11 (KJV)
“Being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself, and became

*obedient unto death, even
the death of the cross.*

*⁹Wherefore God also hath
highly exalted him, and
given him a name which is
above every name: ¹⁰That
at the name of Jesus every
knee should bow, of things
in heaven, and things in
earth, and things under the
earth; ¹¹And that every
tongue should confess that
Jesus Christ is Lord, to the
glory of God the Father.”*

- All the blessings Heaven
can afford... Heaven has
unlimited resources and we
have become heir to it all.

I would like to refer you once again to Webster's definition of the word "*Paradox*," "*A statement that is seemingly contradictory or opposed to common sense and yet is perhaps true.*" Everything I have preached on the last few weeks most certainly contradicts common sense, but where we make a break with Webster's definition in that he says, "*...is perhaps true.*"

These things are absolutely true: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Jesus experienced a human birth so that we could

experience a spiritual birth...

- Jesus occupied a stable so that we could occupy a mansion...
- Jesus accepted an earthly mother so that we could receive a heavenly Father...
- Jesus became subject to human limitations so that we could be set free from sin's restrictions...
- Jesus was received by lowly shepherds so that we could be welcomed by heavenly angels...
- Jesus vacated His glory so that we could share His glory...

